

The Last Straw

Prose Poetry

In the billowing belly of the beast, forms a little red straw.
Packed, shipped, unwrapped, poked through the top of your morning coffee.
Sip, toss, forget.
5 minutes.
The wind carries it to the road.
The rain carries it to a gutter.
The gutter to a drain.
The drain to a river.
The river to the sea.

And there, in the vast blue ocean, with gently jaunting jellyfish and turtles contentedly crunching coral, sits the rigid red straw.
It catches a current, swirling amongst the swarming sardines, and as the silver tuna widens his mouth and rushes at his prey, he swallows the straw.
The straw never disappears. It splinters, breaks, fragments, smaller and smaller, out of sight but ever-present, poisoning its host.
For centuries,
it remains.

Now you may think this doesn't affect you, though that tuna could be your dinner.
You might think: leave the problem for the future to deal with,
We should just live our lives? At what cost? Sacrificing the lives of our children, grandchildren, great-grandchildren so we can continue living in blissful ignorance? Continue using our practical tupperware?
How many times must the little red straw's story be repeated? How many animals must die because of our actions, our inaction?

There is plastic in the water we drink, the food we eat, the air we breathe.
How long until we decide it's time to stop.

Every year,
We produce hundreds of millions of tons of plastic.

A million pieces that find their way into our oceans.

A million animals that never survive the encounter.

Fish and sharks, turtles, dolphins, and even birds, who, in their sanctuary high in the sky, still
cannot escape the plague we've caused.

Floating garbage patches three times the size of France. Soon the area of trash will exceed the
area of land. By 2050 there will be more pieces of plastic than fish in the sea.

And still we do nothing.

How much longer will we favor the green in our pockets over the green of Mother Nature, of
OUR home. How long until we decide to stop?

And yes, it is a decision. Every time you buy plastic, throw it away, pass it on the street, and
leave it, even though you know that THAT piece of garbage will outlive you and your children,
and your grandchildren, and live on forever, you decided.

Yet still, we go on, play along, act like everything is okay.

In Lebanon, garbage piles get so high that, when they collapse, they flow through the streets and
the forest and the sea like an apocalyptic river.

How much longer until we wake up, stand up, rise up, and DO something?

From the small scampering hermit crab to the majestic whistling whale.

Hermit crabs mistake plastic for shells and are killed by the chemical residue. Dead whales wash
up on the beaches with hundreds of pounds of plastic in their stomachs. Turtles can't breathe
because plastic straws get stuck in their nostrils. Birds mistake plastic for food, feeding it to their
hungry offspring.

How long until we realize that this is NOT normal.

Pollution is NOT normal.

Pollution isn't tomorrow's problem.

It's already in our food, in our water, in our blood, in our lungs.

But if we work together. Reduce waste. Take initiative. Recycle. We can turn these straws into
gold.

First, all of us, every single person on this Earth, we have to stand up and decide that it's been
too long, that THIS is the last straw.

-----Addendum: The Numbers-----

That straw, one of over 350 million tons of plastic used yearly.

Average use of a straw: 16 minutes.

That straw can take 1000 years to decompose.

That straw is one of 8 million tons of plastic dumped into our oceans annually.